TRUMAN'S PASSION FOR MUSIC

Harry Truman had a deep love for music—but not for jazz. He found jazz lacking in the melody, harmony, and structure that he believed made music lasting and meaningful.

Truman studied classical piano in Kansas City under Grace White, a distinguished pianist who had trained with Theodor Leschetizky and Fannie Bloomfield-Zeisler, two celebrated figures in classical piano. As a young man, Truman was disciplined and self-motivated, rising at 5 a.m. to practice for two hours each morning. "She didn't have to force me to practice my lessons because I always wanted to do it," Truman once told a reporter. "I liked it and I like music. I like piano music."

At age 20, Truman performed Mendelssohn's *Song Without Words* in a student recital organized by White in May 1904. The program misspelled his name as "Trueman"—not the first time an extra "e" had mistakenly crept in.

Financial pressures at home eventually forced Truman to set aside his musical ambitions. In 1906, he left a Kansas City bank job to work full-time on his family's farm in Grandview, Missouri. As journalist Anthony Leviero wrote in a 1950 *New York Times* profile, Truman's lessons ended just as Jelly Roll Morton and other pioneers were shaping early jazz. "But jazz was foreign to his environment and to his nature," Leviero noted, "and it has never crept into his repertoire."

Still, Truman never hesitated to show off his piano skills when the opportunity arose. One memorable moment came in February 1945, just three weeks into his vice presidency, when he played the piano at the National Press Club while actress Lauren Bacall perched on top of it. The stunt received national attention. What piece he played is unknown, and what his wife Bess said afterward is also lost to history—but Truman later admitted it "caused me a hell of a lot of trouble at home."

Throughout his life, Truman would often stop to play the piano whenever he found one. "It seemed hard for him to pass a piano anywhere without sitting down and playing even a minute or two," remembered Rex Scouten, a White House usher who later became its curator.

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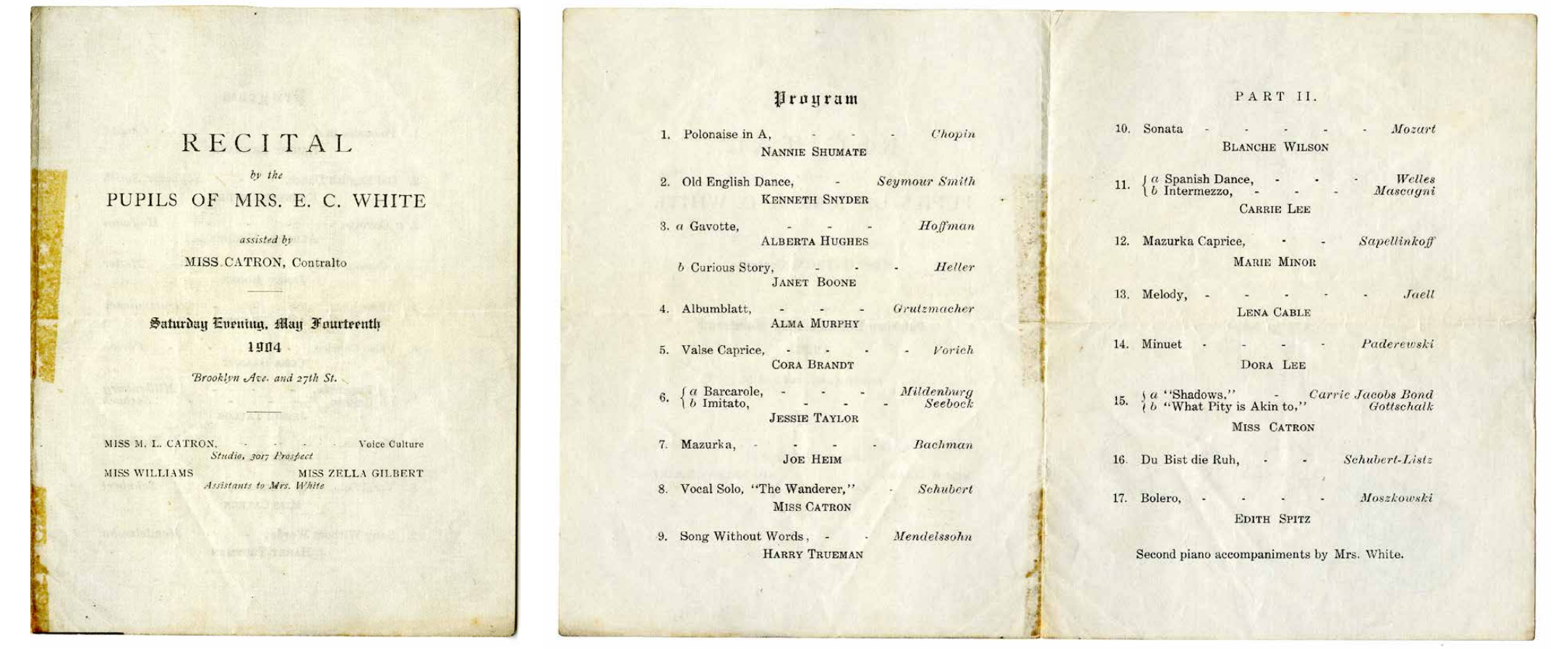

RECITAL
by the
PUPILS OF MRS. E. C. WHITE
assisted by
MISS CATRON, Contralto

Saturday Evening, May Fourteenth
1904
Brooklyn Ave. and 27th St.

MISS M. L. CATRON, - - - - Voice Culture
Studio, 3017 Prospect
MISS WILLIAMS MISS ZELLA GILBERT
Assistants to Mrs. White

Program

1. Polonaise in A, - - - - *Chopin*
NANNIE SHUMATE
2. Old English Dance, - *Seymour Smith*
KENNETH SNYDER
3. *a* Gavotte, - - - *Hoffman*
ALBERTA HUGHES
b Curious Story, - - - *Heller*
JANET BOONE
4. Albumblatt, - - - *Grutzmacher*
ALMA MURPHY
5. Valse Caprice, - - - - *Vorich*
CORA BRANDT
6. *a* Barcarole, - - - - *Mildenburg*
b Imitato, - - - - *Seebock*
JESSIE TAYLOR
7. Mazurka, - - - - *Bachman*
JOE HEIM
8. Vocal Solo, "The Wanderer," - *Schubert*
MISS CATRON
9. Song Without Words, - - *Mendelssohn*
HARRY TRUEMAN

PART II.

10. Sonata - - - - - *Mozart*
BLANCHE WILSON
11. *a* Spanish Dance, - - - *Welles*
b Intermezzo, - - - *Mascagni*
CARRIE LEE
12. Mazurka Caprice, - - *Sapellinkoff*
MARIE MINOR
13. Melody, - - - - - *Jaell*
LENA CABLE
14. Minuet - - - - *Paderewski*
DORA LEE
15. *a* "Shadows." - *Carrie Jacobs Bond*
b "What Pity is Akin to," *Gottschalk*
MISS CATRON
16. Du Bist die Ruh, - - *Schubert-Liszt*
17. Bolero, - - - - *Moszkowski*
EDITH SPITZ

Second piano accompaniments by Mrs. White.

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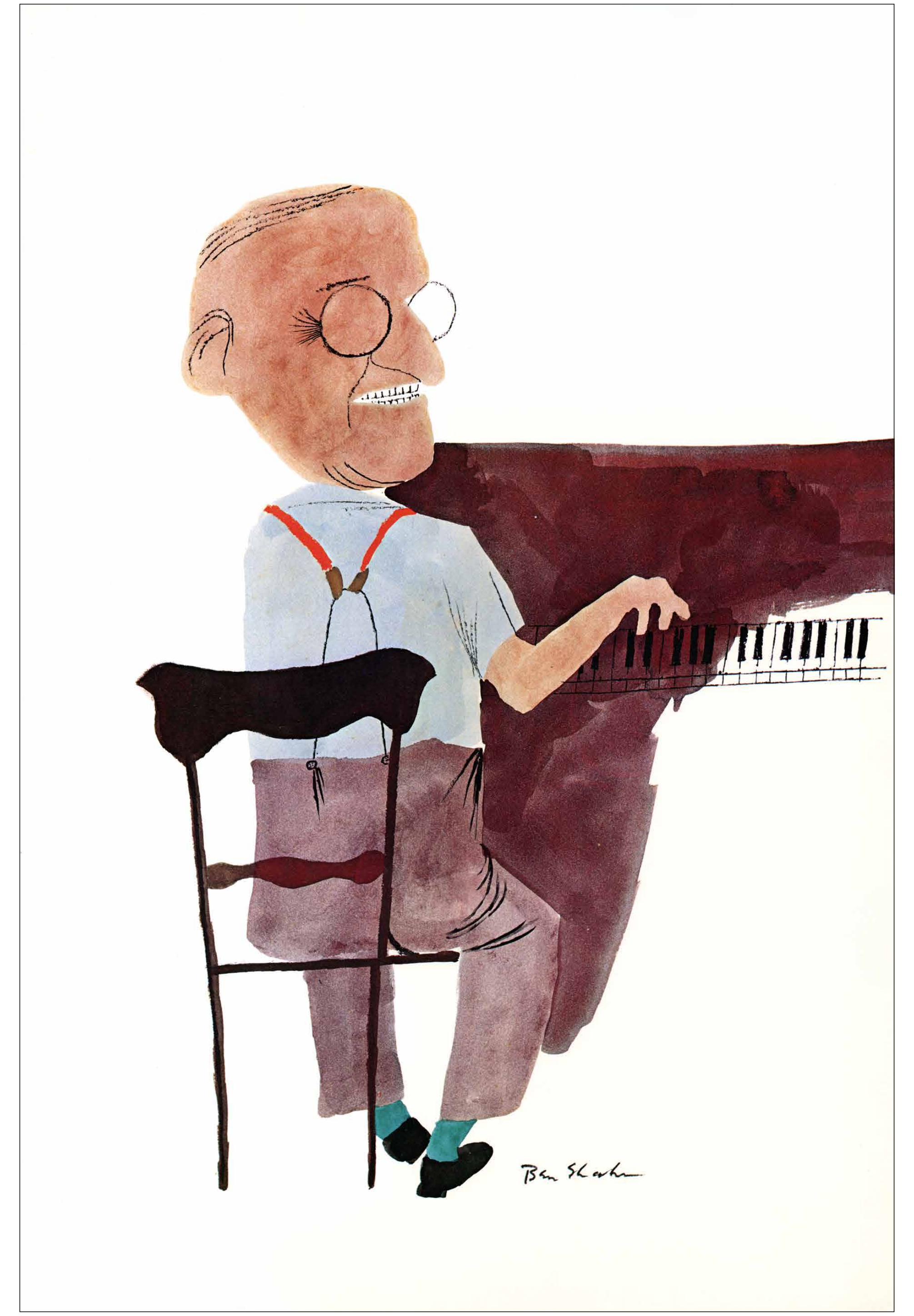

Truman's musical tastes leaned toward the classical, and he wasn't shy about expressing his opinions. During a May 1951 White House event for National Music Week, he remarked: "I have no objection to the noise they call music these days, any more than I have to the 'daubs' they call art these days, but I would like to see you continue to interest people in good music."

He even played during a live 1955 segment of *Person to Person*, when his daughter Margaret Truman filled in as host and interviewed her parents from their Independence, Missouri home.

Reflecting on his life, Truman often expressed a wistful regret: "I've often thought that the country would have been much better off if I'd gone ahead and been a musical pianist … rather than to have gone into politics and be the president of the United States."

Music remained a source of comfort for him. "I had to learn to appreciate great music, particularly piano music," he once said. "I have some of the records of the greatest piano players in the world, and when I'm lonesome at home by myself I play them."

His home in Independence holds a collection of over 680 records—mostly classical and Broadway selections. Very few are jazz.

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